

3rd Class Plan B: Clark, Bridge, and New York

April 1st to 3rd, 2011

Clark Mountain (7,907'), Bridge Mountain (6,955'), New York Mountains High Point (7,533')

CA & NV Border to West of Las Vegas

The weekend started out on a rather sour note as a planned winter climb of the Whitney Mountaineer's Route with Steve Eckert and Jen Blackie fell through at the last minute.

Oh look there's a front coming in. Low of 9 degrees, no big deal. An inch or two of snow, no biggie. Winds 25 mph with gusts up to 50, umm...

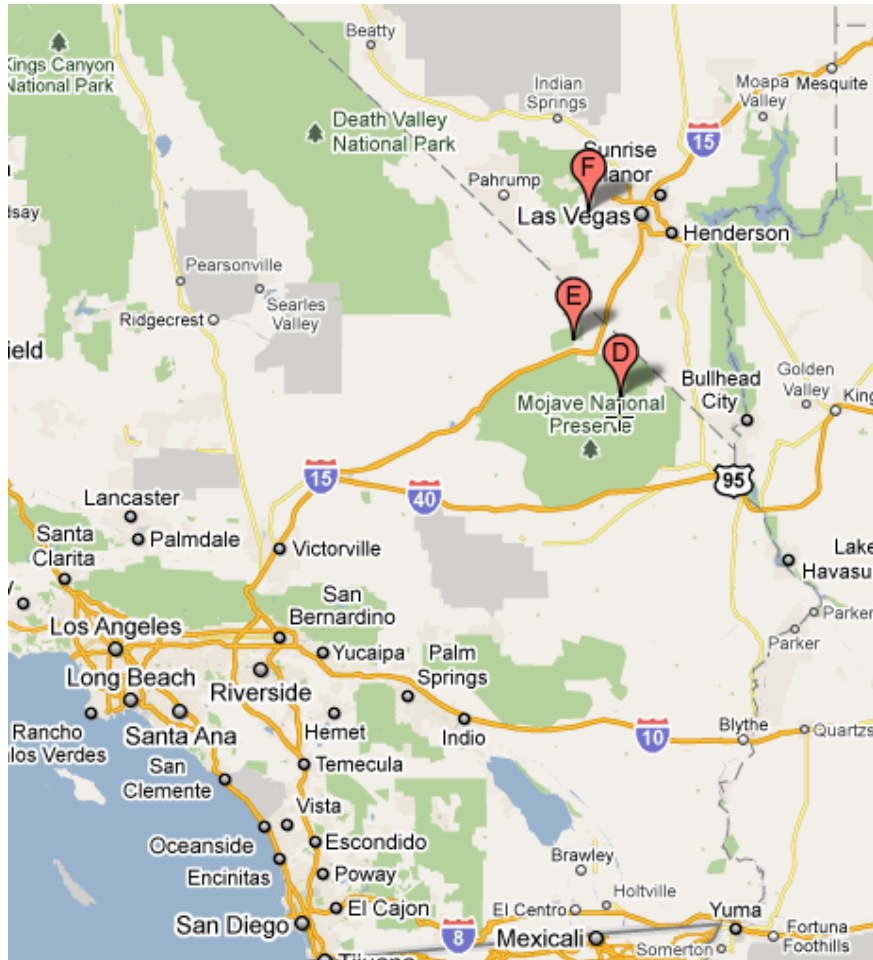
After much deliberation Steve declined to be blown off the Sierra crest like a mountaineer shaped kite which left me in need of something to do that weekend. Not being one to let a little setback keep me at home I spent a frantic few hours at the Vegas airport researching options.

Yet another evening where my friends get a call "I'm leaving on a three day trip in 6 hours, want to go!"

A rather disappointed Miss Blackie was able to be convinced to come along for a desert trip which while also showing a forecast for high winds appeared to be a better call than trying the Eastern Sierra. In addition with moderate mileage each day Kim Breul came along.



Our goals for the weekend were Clark Mountain, Bridge Mountain, and New York Mountains High Point. All three were 3rd class DPS peaks in the greater Las Vegas / Nevada border area.



One three hour flight delay later the planned late pm departure Thursday night was out of the question.

On the plus side I did get this rather neat shot of the strip as we took off.



Arriving in Orange County around 9 pm I went home, packed, stole an hour or two of sleep, then woke up and by 4 am Kim and I were headed for UCI to grab Jen.

Friday April 1st: Clark Mountain

4:30 am we picked up Jen at her dorm and made a beeline for Vegas. It was mid morning by the time we exited the 15 and drove past a mining operation and down a series of decent dirt roads to the Clark trailhead. I was surprised to find a decently equipped primitive campground back there complete with several tables, an elaborate barbeque, and various debris shot full of holes. (Hey, it's the desert, everything has bullet holes)



The DPS peak guide lists the peak as 2 miles and 1900 ft of gain with an all but trivial approach.



The initial route takes you up a somewhat rocky gully until it opens up and gives you a view of the summit.

I caught sight of a plane wreck off to our right and decided to divert to take a look. Jen was all for it and Kim was...following behind.





I hope the bullet holes were made after the plane crashed but you never know in the desert.

With no bodies or other loot we swung back toward the cliffs below the peak and quickly found the area that made Clark a 3rd class summit.



Yep, that's it right there. You could protect it and there was a sling around a tree up higher though we didn't bother.

From there the guide describes easy 2-3 class terrain but we didn't hit anything past 2nd.

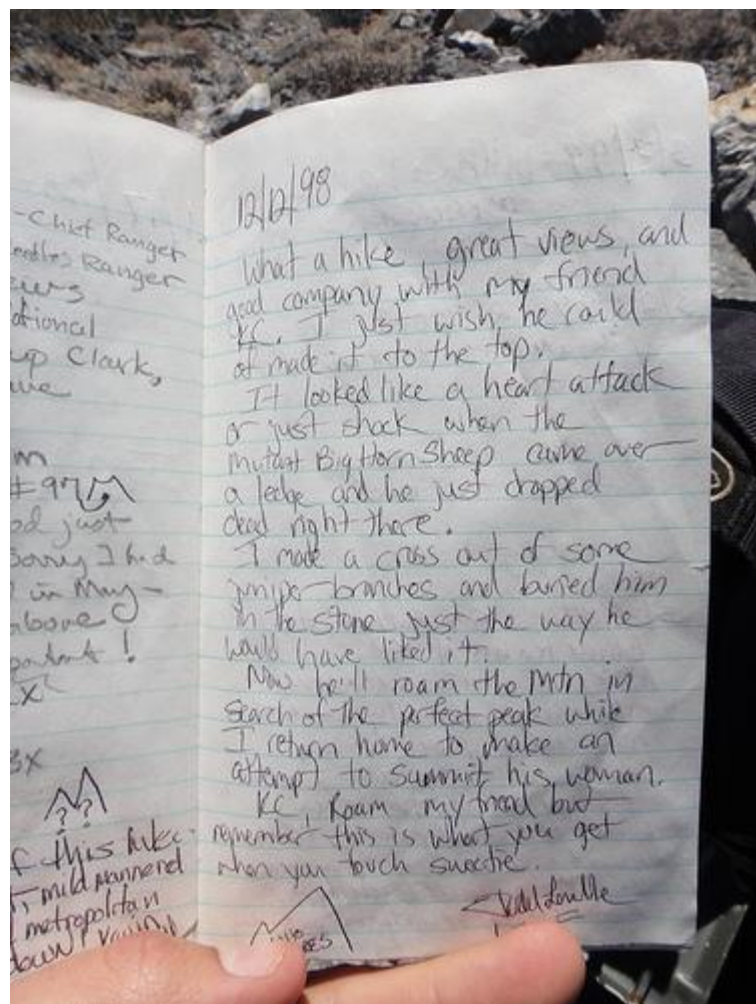


We found another benchmark on one of the bumps along the ridge but it was otherwise unremarkable.



We arrived up top and enjoyed a slightly hazy view. So far the weather was warm but otherwise ideal.

Some people just sign in to the registers while others work on their comedy routine





Instead of returning via the same route I swung us out a ridge and we picked our way down to an alternate trailhead. We hit a bit of the usual loose steep desert terrain but nothing that caused a real issue.

We returned to the car to find one of the local mine employees had driven by and checked on us. He'd apparently noticed the plastic under shield hanging off the bottom of my Rav4 attached with a ziptie and a piece of pink string and helpfully left a note saying I may have knocked something loose.

We briefly discussed camping there but as it was still early we decided to make the drive into Vegas. After, of course, a brief stop at state line for slurpies.

A few slurpies and wrong turns in Vegas later we drove past Red Rocks and into the Spring Mountains.



We arrived a bit before dark at the dirt road turnoff to the Bridge trailhead. Across the road was a small primitive campsite that we adopted as our home for the night.



We used one of the established fire rings and had a rather nice fire but by 9:30 pm I was done and headed for my sleeping bag.

Saturday April 2nd: Bridge Mountain Near Rock Rocks NV

All three of us slept out on the ground and we awoke with our bags soaking wet due to the humidity.

The dirt road to the trailhead was signed as 549 and lead up to Red Rocks Summit. You can actually take the road up from the opposite side inside Red Rocks itself though it requires an entrance fee and was a little more public.

I actually parked where I thought the 4wd section was starting only to realize I could have gone up a bit further as far as a fairly decent primitive campsite. Ah well, bonus mileage!





Past that the road gets really bad, the only thing we saw drive it was a pair of jeeps as we were coming out and even they were inching forward very carefully.





Reaching the saddle below Red Rocks Summit a very clear use trail headed off to the east. This continued a few miles through forest hills giving a nice view off to the north before grabbing a ridge.



From here we found a sign naming both our goal, Bridge, and another nearby peak called North. As they were both listed as the same difficulty I decided to grab North on the way back

Bridge soon came in to view.



Wohoo, giant wrinkled sand booby of the desert!

The game during the approach became trying to pick out a climbable route as from a distance the thing looks all but unclimbable until you're right underneath.

Our approximate route:



The trail fades out once you reach the rock but a series of ducks and spray painted lines and arrows make the route abundantly clear in all but a few places. And unlike say Little Picacho these are somewhat useful here.

The approach winds through a series of bite sized 3rd class sections before crossing a large span to Bridge itself.









Several points early on there were ledges with spectacular exposure off to the side.

The predicted wind had also made an appearance which made a few exposed bits rather interesting. Nothing like having to hunker down on the rocks and hold on while the wind slams into you.

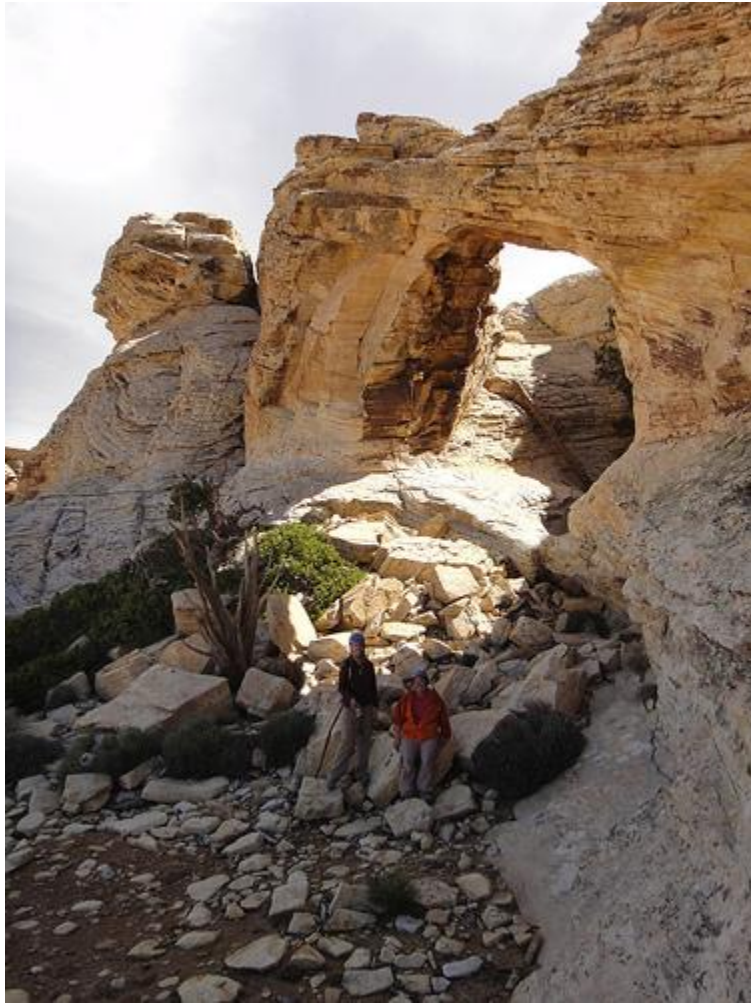


The peak still looked unclimbable but as we crossed over to the base we could pick out the crack that had to be our route. Sure enough once we were right under it it was much more approachable.





Once past that we reached the feature that gave the mountain its name, a natural rock bridge.



Behind the bridge is a small pool of water with a tree barely hanging on to a small patch of soil.



We poked around and followed some ducks off to the side of the bridge.



It turned out these were a false trail. They led to another pool, maybe 6+ ft deep, but there didn't appear to be any decent routes higher from there.



So we backtracked and went across the top of the bridge. I made some comment about how if the bridge collapsed right now it would probably be named after us but the other two didn't find this amusing.



Once across there was a small climb to get on top of the front rock structure.



And then we could see the peak itself. Much more approachable from this close.



Between the actual summit and us there was a rather interesting feature; a hideaway with enough dirt to support several surprisingly large trees.



It would make a decent backpacking destination though you'd have to haul the packs up the previous bits.

The climb beyond the trees exposed us to hammering winds. It was fun.



We did have a nice view of what I believe was Charleston in the distance.



Now directly below the summit we traversed around some easy ledges before climbing for the top.



Surprisingly we found patches of snow up there though they were melting quickly.



And then we were at the summit.



Some of us stood tall...



While others took a somewhat more relaxed pose...



Interestingly enough the Bridge Mountain marked on the maps is actually this lower and much less interesting looking point.



We had a long enough day ahead of us I declined to run over to it...this time.

4/2/11 DPs/WTC
VERY windy day!
Halfway through Clark Bridge NY
Matthew Hengst M
Jen Blackie
Kim Brew M





I took a video up top that didn't really come out but it did show how strong the wind was.

We could see out to the Vegas strip in the distance.



We spent about ten minutes up top before getting chilly deciding to descend. Now we just had to make it down and back to the car.

We revived Miss Kim and started down the same way we'd come up.



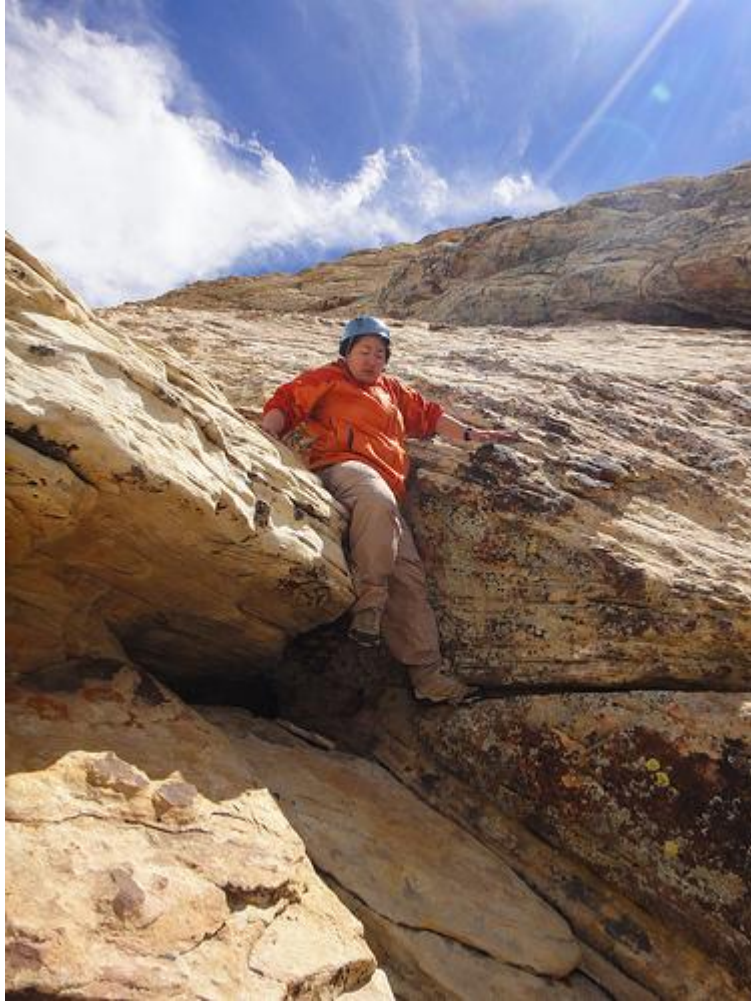
We met another group at the initial large crack and waited at the ledge above for them to come through. As it turned out two of them turned back below and the other two only went up as far as the bridge.







We ran into another pair further back with slightly less protective gear than we had (the woman was wearing shorts, a t-shirt, and bikini)



Here's a shot looking back at what we'd climbed

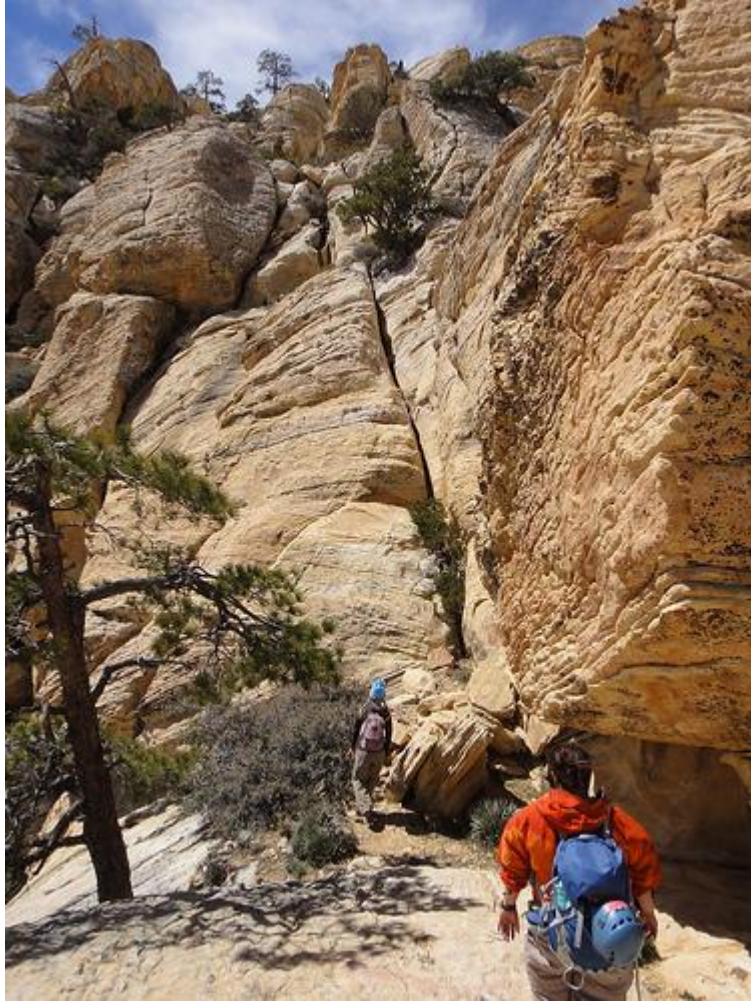


One of the groups asked us if we'd seen the t-something which apparently meant pool or water on the rock. We'd missed it on the way in though I'd seen one in the distance and we went looking for it.



Neat! The water was a bit on the dirty / stagnant side though.

We continued our stroll out.



Once we were back to the trail Jen and I ran over to look at North Peak.



“Difficult” my twice contused rear end.

After that it was just a stroll down the trail and then road back to our vehicle.

Again we decided it was early enough we’d relocate to the next trailhead. This gave us the chance for a quick Chipotle stop in Vegas where we might have been slightly underdressed compared to the other patrons.

We pulled into the New York trailhead not long after dark. Again we had it to ourselves and took advantage of the small fire ring.



We had a small fire but high winds were still in full force now and we ended up putting it out early and heading to bed.

Day 3: New York Mountains High Point

Again all three of us just slept out on the ground and while I woke up a few times due to high winds hitting my sleeping bag overall it was another restful night outdoors.



As it turned out we were only camped about 100 feet from where we ended up leaving the car.



We were doing the Keystone Canyon route which would run us past at least one mine, another interest of mine.

After following the heavily eroded road for a while we turned into a canyon and headed for the mine marked on the map. We could see the peak now.



It's the bump on the right.

We reached the mine after finding a large amount of debris that had apparently been swept down the wash over the years. Great location for a mine...



I of course took off looking for shaft openings but only found this.



Unfortunately it was so flooded we couldn't go in but it did go back a ways.

We followed the route up the hill behind the mine and soon caught sight of a second opening higher up in the wash. Jen and I hustled over while Kim waited back on the route.





Not bad though due to how fragile the rock was the shaft collapsed about 200 ft back.



We did find this little guy though.



No idea why there was only one bat.

We came back out and saw Kim waiting for us across the way. She was somewhat less thrilled by the bat than we had been.



We climbed the slope until we gained the ridge and headed for our bump.



It actually looked rather trivial to climb from a distance but would prove otherwise.



We noticed right off the large amount of lady bugs smeared across the rocks and plants. I've seen this a few times and it's always rather neat.



Our first attempt to climb the summit from the east ended up cliffing out rather decidedly. We came back down, circled around to the north west, and picked up some ducks.

Some bushwhacking was required...



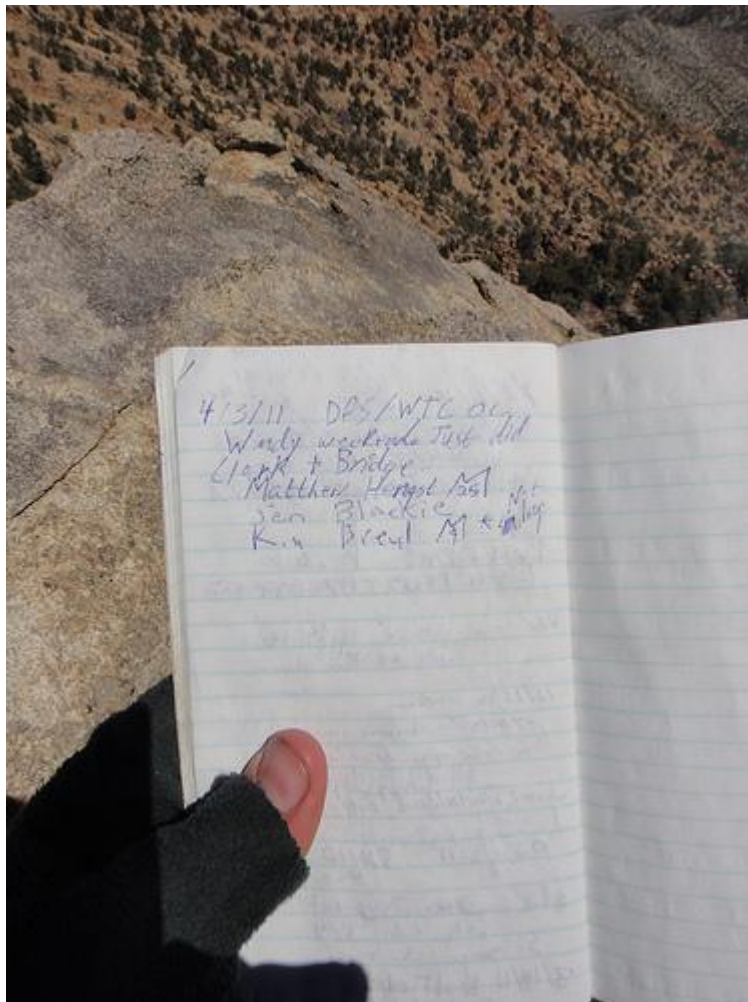
After that we had some large boulders to maneuver across.



Between Jen and I we tried to make things as easy as possible for a very tired Miss Kim.



After a few surprisingly interesting 3rd class bits we arrived at the top.



Some of us were slightly less thrilled than others.

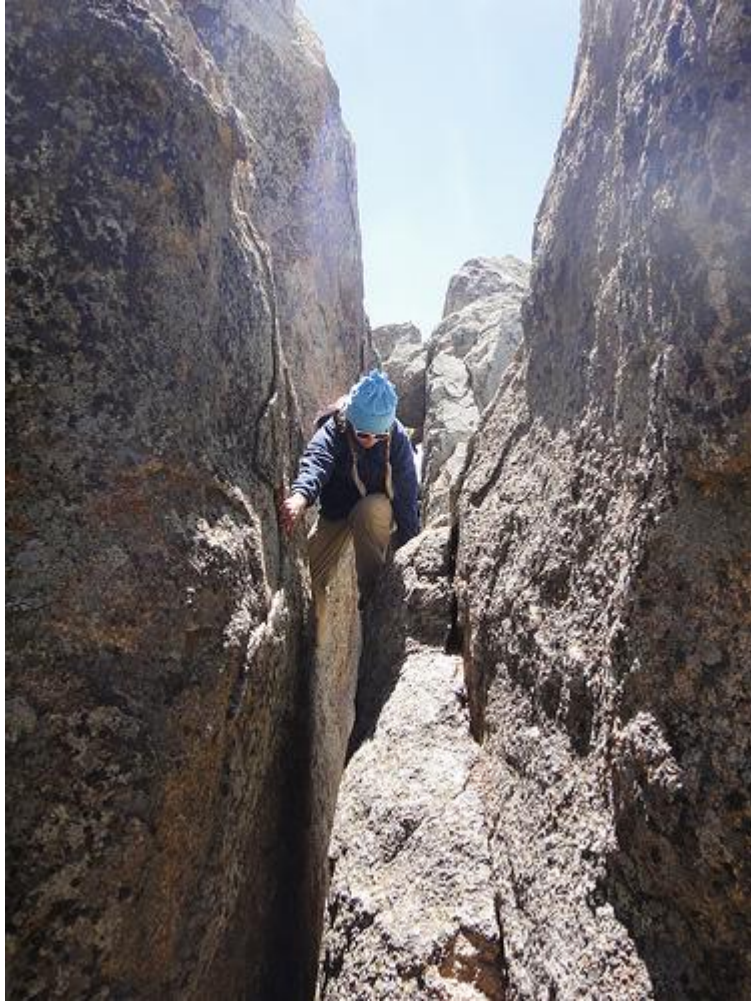






Now came the descent.





Rather than return via the ridge and mine I took us off along a different ridge that ran to the east towards a large white mound above where our vehicle was parked.

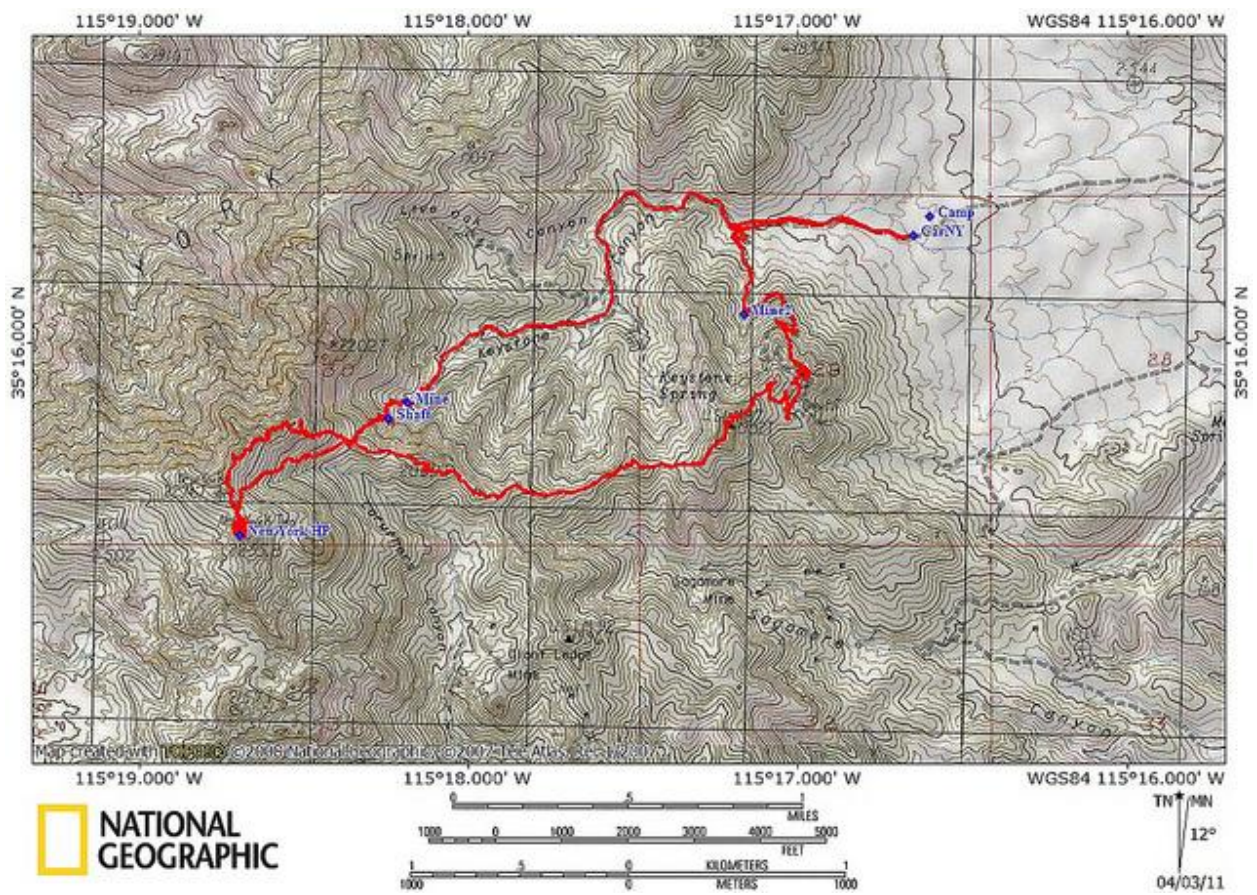


This proved to be somewhat slow going but gave us the opportunity to visit another mine.

The peak right above the mine several hours later.



Sadly the mine site was a disappointment. The main area had very clearly been cleaned up and the only opening we found was down lower on the road and it was again too flooded to get inside.



You can see the standard DPS route to the north and our return ridge traverse further south.

From there it was just a matter of getting home. This was complicated by Vegas traffic along the 15 but with Kim to help me drive we made it back to Orange County around 9:30 pm.

Plenty of time to get ready to fly back to Boise the following morning.

So overall not a bad weekend. Three days and three 3rd class peaks that had been on my want list for a while now.

I checked on the other groups that had been scheduled to head up Whitney that same weekend and near as I could tell only two had actually tried it in the face of the bad forecast. Their trip report was filled with accounts of high wind wag bag maneuvers and not summing so it appeared we'd made a good choice. Steve had successfully made Carillion before the bad weather came in but even down there the snow was bad.

Next week was Alabama Hills with SCMA and then it's back to the mountains for another attempt at a snow climb.